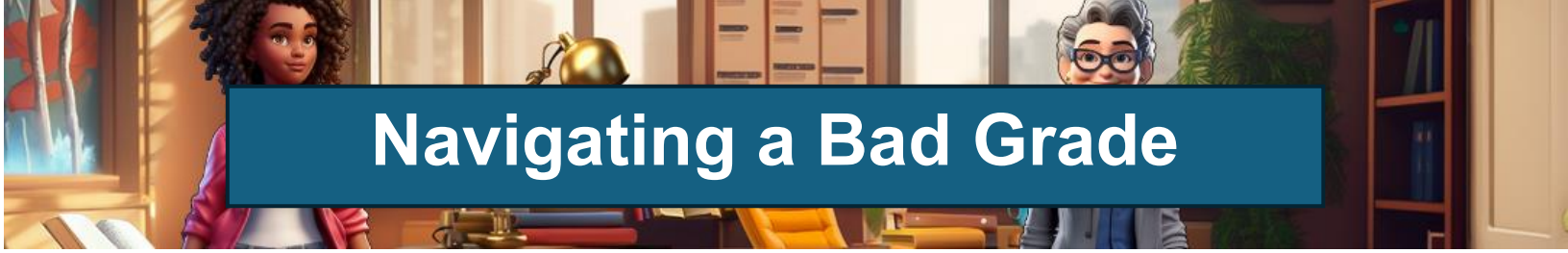

Navigating a Bad Grade

At some point, we may get a grade that we think is wrong or unfair.

There are a variety of knee-jerk reactions we all have in those moments. Some of us want to shut ourselves alone in our dorm room and cry, while others may have the impulse to rush into the instructor's office yelling and demanding the grade be changed.

However, neither of those reactions will be effective and may only make the situation much worse.

1

Take some time to cool off.

When you are upset about a grade, it is hard to see the situation objectively.

2

Review the grading rubric. Does the grading align with the criteria?

Review the feedback. Is it reasonable?

Could there be an honest mistake?

3

If you think you were graded unfairly, set up an appointment to meet with the instructor

Aim for a respectful conversation:

Try to keep the discussion focused by framing what you say in terms of

The question/rubric asked for … [and then explain how your answer/paper met those requirements].

Ask appropriate questions about how your grade was calculated.

1. Ask for examples of what would have made your work stronger.
2. Try to understand what your instructor thinks is missing or incorrect about your work.
3. Focus on objective criteria (i.e. things that can be measured, or valid and recognized standards for evaluating the merits of work).
4. Use a flat, neutral, inquisitive tone of voice.

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https://sites.google.com/view/gears-game/

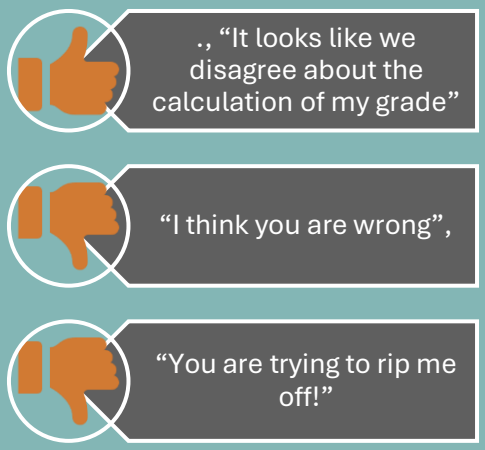
Navigating a Bad Grade

In the discussion <u>don't:</u>

- Accuse them of cheating you, even if you believe they have done that. Making such an accusation is much more likely to cause the instructor to resist hearing your point of view!
- Give up trying to gain a clear understanding of the instructor's stated reasons for assigning you the grade.
- Use a tone of voice which conveys anger or disrespect

What if, after discussing the issue with the instructor, you are convinced that your grade does not reflect the merits of your work?

- *Politely* indicate that you and the instructor appear to be in disagreement about how the grade should have been calculated.



- Ask if they can suggest any alternatives for resolving the disagreement. At this point, informal options to resolve the issue are limited to choices with which both you and the instructor can agree.

Feedback from another instructor?

A review from a TA?

- If there is no resolution and you still wish to pursue the matter, you can appeal your grade.

Speak with the department chair in the instructor's department.	Follow a formal grade appeal procedure.	Check the course outline/syllabus for the process	Or, check the postsecondary calendar regulations.

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